


Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

**AIR APPARENT** Capt. G.R. Gopinath, Jun. 2005

LOW-COST AIRLINES, 2003

# NO-FRILLS TAKES OFF

**Air Deccan shattered the myth that flying was an elite pursuit. With no-frills service and ultra-low fares, it transformed Indian aviation, inspiring a booming budget airline segment**

BY AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

In 2003, Gorur Ramaswamy Iyengar Gopinath, a retired captain of the Indian Army, introduced Indians to what at first sounded like an oxymoron: low-cost airline. In the India of the 1990s and the early noughties, flying was the preserve of the well-heeled. The others took trains.

Gopinath imagined an India where airlines did just one job: transport people from one place to another without making a big deal out of it. Thus he started Air Deccan with a flight from Bangalore to Hubbali in Karnataka on August 25, 2003. It was a domestic carrier minus the meal service, plush seats and the sundry other bells and whistles that full-service carriers of the time, like Indian Airlines and Jet Airways, offered.

Suddenly, the ordinary Indian could dream of flying. A bus driver in Bengaluru, a shopkeeper in Jaipur or a student in Guwahati, they could all board a plane for just Rs 500. Flying became a practical, time-saving alternative to overnight trains and gruelling